

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

The Origins of the Cold War

US.60 — Analyze the Cold War policies of containment and the Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, and Berlin Airlift.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Read the following three primary source excerpts and then respond to the prompt below. In your response, analyze each document using the HIPP framework (Historical context, Intended audience, Purpose, Point of view) and construct an evidence-based argument.

The sources

Document A

George Kennan, "The Long Telegram," February 22, 1946 — declassified U.S. State Department cable, available through the National Archives

“We have here a political force committed fanatically to the belief that with US there can be no permanent modus vivendi, that it is desirable and necessary that the internal harmony of our society be disrupted, our traditional way of life be destroyed, the international authority of our state be broken, if Soviet power is to be secured.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document B

Winston Churchill, "The Sinews of Peace" (Iron Curtain Speech), Westminster College, Fulton, Missouri, March 5, 1946 — public address, transcript available through Westminster College archives

“From Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic, an iron curtain has descended across the Continent. Behind that line lie all the capitals of the ancient states of Central and Eastern Europe... all are subject in one form or another, not only to Soviet influence but to a very high and in many cases increasing measure of control from Moscow.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document C

Harry S. Truman, Address to Congress (Truman Doctrine), March 12, 1947 — U.S. government document, National Archives

“At the present moment in world history nearly every nation must choose between alternative ways of life. The choice is too often not a free one. One way of life is based upon the will of the majority... The second way of life is based upon the will of a minority forcibly imposed upon the majority.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT C

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using all three documents and your knowledge of Cold War origins (US.59-US.60), construct an argument that evaluates the relative roles of ideology and geopolitical strategy in causing the Cold War. Apply HIPP analysis to at least two of the three documents and use outside historical knowledge to support your argument. Your response

1. what each document reveals about U.S./Western perceptions of the Soviet threat
2. whether the Cold War was primarily an ideological conflict or a geopolitical competition for power; and
3. whether alternative outcomes were possible given the structural conditions of 1945–1947

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Document C		
Outside knowledge		

